

Nerd's Hell and Nerd's Haven

Modern formal learning takes place with age-graded peers. Peers, therefore, are a significant social context for child development. When children depart early childhood and enter middle childhood (approximately between ages six and twelve), they become more oriented toward the social world beyond their family. However, in the modern world, the beginning of middle childhood coincides with the onset of schooling. Therefore, the major shift in children's social world is from home to school. Although they have less parental supervision, they continue to be supervised by schoolteachers and other school staff. What is dramatically changed is that children now spend much of their daily time with same-age peers.

Much developmental research documents the significant role peer context plays in child development.¹ Middle childhood is a period during which children's mental capacity increases (in addition to their increased physical capacity), particularly in the area of social cognition.² Whereas they are less able to appreciate how other people's minds work, they now are more sophisticated in their understanding. They now realize that what they know may not be known by others and what they see may not be seen by others; that is, other people have their own minds and do their own thinking. They become increasingly sophisticated in their ability to take new perspectives. They can anticipate, interpret, and explain others' desires, thoughts, and actions more accurately, independent of what they themselves desire, think, and do. Socially, they experience intensive peer interactions. They become interested in peer relationships, friendship, and their own social standing among peers, but at the same time, they care about their own quality, competence, and independence.³

Along with all of these developmental changes, children attend school and are under pressure to achieve. It is therefore important to understand how children's social experience with peers influences their learning and

achievement in school. There is much more research on how Western children navigate and fare through these processes than how children in other cultures do so. Research involving Western children shows that when they have good peer relations and higher social standing, they tend to achieve higher.⁴ This general finding is not surprising given the importance of children's social needs. It is not hard to see that a well-liked child feels safe and free of peer-related worry and can therefore focus on intellectual tasks in school. This positive social support from peers can also boost the child's self-esteem and self-confidence, which can generate higher learning motivation. But when a child is not well liked, is ignored, rejected, or even bullied, that child may fear school and may not be able to learn well.⁵

Despite all this informative research, there has been relatively less research on how peers regard each other as learners. In other words, how do children view each other as a result of the inevitable disparities in achievement? In this chapter, I thread pieces of research together in order to shed light on this neglected but important research topic. I make three claims. First, how children regard each other as learners/achievers has a significant impact on how they respond to, interact with, relate to, and treat each other. Second, the particular attitude children have toward their learning and achieving peers has serious consequences to children's further learning (in addition to their general social development and well-being). Third, children's attitudes toward their learning and achieving peers are profoundly shaped by the values of their respective cultures. Western and East Asian cultures offer an excellent contrastive perspective on these processes and outcomes.

THE WESTERN LEARNER IN THE EYE OF THE PEERS

In the West, if one is incredibly lucky, one's peer in middle school and high school may become one's friend.⁶ More often, a peer in school is a competitor, a stressor, and – with surprising commonality – a harasser.⁷ Desire to excel, or at least not to come below their peers, makes school a competitive setting.⁸ A peer is a stressor because one frequently worries about how one is viewed by peers, and how one might run the risk of not being liked and consequently being excluded from peer groups.⁹ A peer can become a harasser if one is singled out as a target to be picked on, ridiculed, or bullied.¹⁰ Moreover, a peer can also be someone to ignore or to neglect, leaving peers in social isolation.¹¹ In Western school culture, peer harassment and victimization, based on extensive research, is quite prevalent.¹²

Nerd's Hell

Most striking and unbelievable (to me, who came from an entirely different culture) is the research finding that those who try to learn and to achieve are tormented with most peer harassment.¹³ In fact, there are terms reserved for students in middle school and high school who are interested, motivated, and make an effort to pursue knowledge. They are infamously called “nerds,” “geeks,” “dorks,” and a host of other derogatory names. This type of peer harassment occurs not only in the United States, but apparently in many Western cultures. In the English-speaking countries of Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, the terms popular in the United States also enjoy popularity. In Britain, the equivalent term for nerd is *swot*,¹⁴ in Germany – *Schreber*, in France – *bouttoneux*,¹⁵ in Holland – *stuud*,¹⁶ and in Israel – *hnun*.¹⁷

What is a nerd? The term¹⁸ is considered to be homegrown in the United States, perhaps with the initial invention by Dr. Seuss for his playful children's rhyme, “a Nerke, a Nerd, and a Seersucker too,” in his book *If I Ran the Zoo*.¹⁹ Soon the term caught the attention of the popular media in the ensuing decades, as exemplified by the sitcom *Happy Days*. By 1960s and 1970s, the term was widespread across the United States and other Western cultures. It is typically used to label a student, more often a boy, during middle school or high school, who is socially and physically awkward. This alone does not earn the boy the title of a “nerd,” however. The key defining attribute is that the boy is *intellectually* curious and makes an effort to pursue his interests (especially science, math, and technology, or else subjects that the rest of the peers find too complex and difficult to comprehend); above all, he is a high achiever in those subjects.²⁰ *American Heritage Dictionary of the English Language* now defines nerd as a “person who is single-minded or accomplished in scientific or technical pursuits but is felt to be socially inept.”²¹ It is this combination of characteristics that gives birth to labeling someone a nerd. Current research indicates that not only boys continue to be labeled as such; girls who show intellectual interest and achieve well are also subject to such labeling. Moreover, the term now extends to children from all ethnicities that fit the image of a nerd, whereas it was initially used exclusively for white boys.²²

If this were just a game of labeling without any serious consequences, it would not be worth anyone's attention. But as Sheldon White²³ cogently argued, a newborn term in a culture signifies an important social reality, such as the term *adolescence* occurring in the Western culture in the

late nineteenth century. The emergence of nerd and similar terms across Western cultures is no exception. As it turns out, labeling a peer as a nerd is a major daily form of peer harassment against those who actually do what schooling is intended for children to do by society, schools, teachers, parents, and children themselves. Unfortunately, any child, once stigmatized as a nerd, becomes the target of open ridicule, verbal taunts, social exclusion, and even physical attacks from peers.²⁴

Research documents that such peer harassment is prevalent. In 1989, N. T. Feather²⁵ asked more than 500 high school students and 300 college students in Australia to respond to scenarios in which either a high achiever or an average achiever experienced failure, in addition to some general attitude toward these two kinds of achievers. He found that these respondents were more pleased to see a high achiever fail than to see an average achiever fail. He also found that high school students were happier with and friendlier toward a high achiever who fell to the average position than toward an average achiever who fell to the bottom. Feather used the apt metaphor of the “fall of the tall poppy” to capture the attitude students express toward high achievers. Moreover, Feather found that the high achiever was viewed as “less sociable and more of a loner than the average achiever.”²⁶ In a follow-up study, Feather used his Tall Polly Scale with some 200 ordinary adults and found that those who had lower self-esteem and attached less importance to the value of achievement expressed more such negative attitudes.

John and Michael Bishop²⁷ recently conducted a large study on how such a peer norm functions in American students’ school engagement and study effort. They interviewed tenth-graders from eight public schools located in predominantly white upper-middle-class suburban towns. This qualitative study enabled them to develop a comprehensive survey, which they administered to more than 110,000 middle-school and high-school students across 325 schools.

What they found was consistent with the studies by Feather and others but with more nuanced insights: students who are *average* in academic ability, pro-learning attitude, and achievement receive the least peer harassment (40–100 incidents per year). Students who fall either at the low end or the high end of the scale – that is, those out of the norm – receive the most peer harassment (120–220 incidents per year). At the lower end, peers harass two very different groups of students: those who are least motivated and are themselves disruptors and slackers (falling below the norm) and those who are perceived as low in ability but try to study hard to raise their achievement (striving to beat the odds, again attempting to go above the

norm). The researchers used the phrase “try but not too hard”²⁸ to describe the peer norm that is strongly enforced in American public schools.

Against this cultural backdrop, students who want to do well in school are afraid of displaying their effort and their achievement. The researchers state: “Typically they are code switchers who affirm the ‘try but not too hard’ norm at school but hit their books when they get home.... Often high levels of effort are kept secret and academic accomplishments down played in order to fit in and to avoid jealousy.”²⁹ The researchers further explain that getting good grades in and of itself is not the probable reason for inviting peer harassment; rather, it is one’s intention, motivation, and behavior that accompany the good grades. If effort is seen by peers as “sucking up” or studying harder in order to get ahead, the effort is likely to be regarded as unfair and thus sanctioned. However,

getting good grades because of a high IQ is not viewed as intentional and is seldom sanctioned. Indeed top grades achieved effortlessly signal high ability – something that peers and parents value a great deal.³⁰ Consequently, high GPA students often avoid peer harassment by claiming not to study, eschewing public displays of interest in academic learning and keeping their grades secret. Many high achieving students gain popularity by pursuing this strategy.³¹

Unless a student possesses an effortless, natural mental gift, he or she would be better off not to try hard. In a study comparing fourth-, sixth-, and eighth-grade students, researchers also found that eighth-graders (fourteen-year-olds), but not the younger children, were reluctant to disclose their diligence (amount of work they did) to their popular peers despite their willingness to disclose their effort to teachers. By eighth grade, children who were once regarded as popular as a result of high ability and hard work dropped lower in popularity. Those who did not work hard regardless of their ability enjoyed the highest peer popularity.³² Another recent study comparing eighth- and ninth-graders in Canada, Germany, and Israel found that fear of peer rejection and ostracism takes a toll on students’ motivation and achievement. The more students buy into this kind of peer culture, the greater the toll. Furthermore, the more prevalently such peer norms exist within the larger culture, the greater this negative impact.³³

These studies compel us to draw the conclusion that in the West there exists a forceful peer culture (at least in public school) that pits academic excellence against peer acceptance; that is, high academic achievement comes at a high social cost. Given that social acceptance by peers is a matter of high concern for children, particularly adolescents, they are forced

to choose between their need to learn well and their need for peer support. They cannot have both unless they possess inborn high intelligence and the ability to do well without trying. The effortful tall poppy is vehemently hacked down by peers initially but eventually by children's diminished motivation for learning. This force, as many researchers acknowledge, is the tyranny of mediocrity. It is quite amazing that this peer culture enjoys longevity and perpetuation even in the face of the concerted effort of parents and schools to motivate children for higher achievement. It is obvious that, as lamented by John and Michael Bishop,³⁴ these adult efforts are canceled out by peer culture to a large extent. This culture makes so much student effort and educational reform utterly futile, much like Sisyphus' pushing his rock up the hill only to watch it roll back down again (according to Greek mythology, Sisyphus was a king who was eternally punished for his mistakes by being made to push a large rock uphill only to watch it roll down again and again).

Sadly, most children do not possess top intelligence and cannot be schooled with "effortless perfection." The Lake Woebegone myth where all children achieve above average, as aptly told by the comedian Garrison Keillor, is just that – a myth. Teachers, parents, and children themselves are keenly aware of the reality. Many children also concur with their parents and teachers that they should learn well, and that the only way to achieve that is to make an effort. For such children, school is hell. Extensive research looking at schoolchildren under peer attack shows that they suffer, among other things, from anxiety, low self-esteem, and depression, not to mention low achievement.³⁵ Such psychological problems can have long-term negative impact on these children well into adulthood.³⁶ It may take years for these people to regain self-confidence. Some need to seek out clinical therapy to restore their mental health. Some may never heal. Parents also are fearful that such misfortune may befall their own children and feel hopeless if this indeed happens. To reduce the risk, parents encourage their children to engage in hobbies, extracurricular activities, and sports, which can increase their children's standing among peers.

My own son attended a public middle school with virtually no diversity in the student body. He happened to be somewhat shy, with below-average athletic prowess. But he was interested in and good at math and did well in school. His name was on the honor roll and adorned the school hallways. His experience was that of a typical nerd, and he was harassed by his peers on a daily basis. Not only did some of the peers verbally taunt and exclude him from peer groups and activities; one big boy once tried to throw him in a trash can. We managed to collect some twelve insulting terms addressed

to him. Each day was an ordeal for both our son and us. If our son came back from school and reported no harassment, it was a day of blessing for him, and my husband and I would feel relief. But the problem became so severe that one day our son refused to go to school, demanding that we either home-school him or send him to a different school.

Unfortunately, this peer culture is fully present and well-functioning much earlier than middle school and high school. Available research indicates that children as young as kindergarteners and first-graders become aware of the double-edged sword of high achievement in the West. As alluded to in [Chapter 3](#), my own research³⁷ using children's story completions shows that at as young as age five, European-American children are cognizant of the social cost of high academic achievement. They are fully aware that while the high-achieving child is very happy for him- or herself (and so are his or her parents and teachers), the peers are "unhappy," "sad," "mad," and "jealous" because the achieving child did better than the peers. Some children reported actual actions taken against high achievers, such as peers not wanting to play with them or saying hurtful words to them. Such peer isolation and rejection make the high achievers scared and worried.

Is It Human Nature to Harass Nerds?

When my husband and I went to see our son's principal and guidance counselor, we proposed to help the school launch a program called "respect for your peers." But our hope was shattered by the school leaders' attribution of such peer problems to human nature – that is, a universal claim that this type of nerd harassment is in the human genes. "Kids are just like that" was what they said. Their belief was that because it is human nature, the school could do nothing to change it.

We could not endure the situation any longer and enrolled our son in a private school where children suddenly were no longer "just like that," and the nature claim crumbled right there. Because his new school did not believe in the nature argument for nerd harassment, or perhaps because most children who enrolled in this new school were nerds themselves, no one was called or harassed as a nerd.³⁸ Luckily, our son made friends and experienced much better school life. The intellectual and the social were finally integrated for him.

For the longest time, psychologists, particularly developmental psychologists, treated this kind of peer culture and harassment as more or less a given. This universal argument found backing from research on animal hierarchy and the pan-cultural existence of social dominance and submission.³⁹

The second support for the view of universality is actually a consequence of research relying on one cultural group, namely that of the West.⁴⁰ This is limitation mistaken as support. Research findings based on Western theories and people were believed to be applicable to people across all cultures, without actually studying these people or these cultures. However, in recent decades, researchers studying other cultural groups have produced evidence that peer culture in school differs from culture to culture,⁴¹ as will be seen in the section on East Asian peer culture. The once held universal peer norm is just one norm of one particular type of culture (even within the West, this norm is not universal, as in the case of my son's new school, and as reportedly observable across the gymnasiums of Europe). It is therefore important to examine the norm of Western peer culture from the perspective of the West as a specific case rather than a universal human norm.

Inescapable Dooming of Nerds in the West

Why are motivated, interested, and serious learners so pejoratively regarded, and why do so many Western peers feel it legitimate to harass their peers for doing what they themselves also would like to do and to achieve? These questions become even more pressing when we consider the West as the culture that introduced and continues to uphold personal rights, human rights, equality, and democratic social order for all. It is a truism that everyone desires safety, respect, and a chance to receive a good education, yet Western school peer culture does not seem to grant it to everyone. In fact, it seems to do the opposite, to undermine these lofty human moral aspirations of the culture.

Based on my review of research and theoretical discussions, there are some plausible reasons for why this peer culture exists and functions the way it does. As discussed in previous chapters, the first and foremost reason has to do with how the individual and the self are defined. Extensive research in psychology shows quite convincingly⁴² that Western people hold a *fixed* view of the self. Accordingly, the self is born with a unique set of characteristics such as temperamental differences that are present at birth and not shared with other individuals. Such unique characteristics are believed to be foundational to the person's eventual personality development. In the sphere of academic learning, many researchers have demonstrated and argued that Western people believe in the existence and validity of ability/intelligence, particularly the inborn nature of it, as well as related personal qualities such as talent, creativity, and style. The uniqueness of these individual qualities is the source of self-esteem and personal pride.⁴³

Therefore, people feel positive about themselves when they achieve well in school because this confirms their sense of self-worth. However, when not achieving well, the self is inevitably implicated as lacking something inherent, usually intelligence, which is regarded as the underlying power for achievement. This realization can be devastating to the person's self-worth.⁴⁴ No one likes to face this personal devastation.

Yet, the schooling process serves to do nothing except to counter this very cultural ethos that celebrates each individual's uniqueness and self-worth. Schooling is a process that is heavily dependent on evaluation of individuals' learning outcomes. All schools, public or private, proceed with frequent assessment of pupils' learning process and achievement. This evaluation-dependent schooling process inevitably leads children to engage in increasing social comparison of who is smart, who is average, who is doing well, who is not, and above all where children themselves stand. Every time a teacher asks a question for children to answer, social comparison of this sort is occurring. The child who answers the question becomes the target for peers' self-other evaluation. And this takes place in addition to the teacher's formal and informal evaluation of children, which lies at the heart of schooling. When the evaluative outcome is favorable, the child is likely to feel good about him- or herself. But when the evaluative outcome is not favorable, the child may feel not only negative about the self, but also resentful toward the target child who is the very cause of the negative self-realization of the evaluating child.⁴⁵

Hence, it is not exaggerating to say that the schooling process is one that breaks most children's sense of self as a unique and great person. The harsh reality is that only a handful of children in any school can ever be truly unique and great in this impersonal process of schooling and may emerge out of the process unscarred. Such children may truly be those who master academic learning with "effortless perfection." Schooling is intended to give most children needed competence, knowledge, and skills for a common life. As such, schooling makes children realize, unavoidably, that they are just ordinary. This is to say that as few children become the redefined unique and great individuals, the rest are likely to experience personal downgrading. In a culture that holds a fixed view of the self, it would be dubious if high achievers would be welcome by peers. Why would they be kind and respectful toward those who are seen as, and probably are, the very cause of their downgrading?

The second reason is that the West, particularly the United States, is an intensely competitive culture. Márta Fülöp, a Hungarian psychologist, studied U.S., Japanese, and Hungarian high school children's understanding

of competition.⁴⁶ She found that all three groups of children acknowledged the prevalence of competition in their school life. However, American children found it most unpleasant and disliked it most. They viewed competition as a zero-sum game, meaning that if one child gets ahead and wins, the rest are necessarily behind and lose. The conceptual importance lies in the idea that competition cannot make both parties winners. Japanese children liked competition most, but they viewed it very differently from their U.S. counterparts. Instead of regarding it as a zero-sum game, Japanese children saw competition as a chance to catch up with their peers, and peers help each other so that all end up doing better in school. Children enjoy this type of competition because both parties are winners in the end. Hungarian children were in the middle, focusing on getting to the top ranks but not necessarily regarding competition as a zero-sum game. Based on her studies, Fülöp concludes that although competition is observed in nature and across the human world, it takes different forms, meanings, and processes depending on the culture and the goals of competition. Competition is thus a culturally constructed concept that guides human action.

Perhaps there is a connection between U.S. children's view of competition as a zero-sum game and the general fixed view of the self. Winning among competitors is the ultimate testimony of self-worth. So long as the individual's self-worth is prized above everyone else, such competition is likely to persist and flourish. These two processes function to feed off each other, making the dynamics reach new heights. Winning validates and solidifies the self that is likely to engage in competition to win. This process can continue as long as one is always the winner. But for those who experience more losing than winning, the assurance of self-worth cannot be sustained. Losing casts doubt on the self, weakens it, and discourages it from making an effort. In other domains of life, people could just abandon the activity at which they do not excel and move on to pursue other activities where they may shine. However, because compulsory education does not allow children to divert their learning time to other activities, they cannot escape academic learning and must face up to the challenges whether or not they personally like them. In academic learning, children become more vulnerable to the zero-sum style of competition and may become indifferent, give up, or, quite likely, turn to harass those who are seen as the cause of their loss.

The third reason is that Western culture seems to hold a talent assumption for intellectual achievement. Talent, as the term suggests, is something that one is born with. This view has deep roots dating back to antiquity.⁴⁷ Again, this idea is consistent with the fixed view of the self. However, this

assumption is not easily refuted when we look at the fact that not all children are born with the same intelligence profile, with some apparently more talented than others in just about any domain of performance. The easily identifiable geniuses such as Mozart, Picasso, Einstein, and Marie Curie, as well as the existence of precocious children in math, science, reading, and writing, all lend support to the talent assumption.⁴⁸ Carol Dweck has studied this assumption for decades.⁴⁹ She uses the terms *entity theory* versus *incremental theory* of intelligence that children and adults hold about school learning. Accordingly, entity theorists believe that one's intelligence is fixed at birth, whereas incremental theorists believe that one's intelligence grows as one learns. Interestingly, Western kindergarteners think that smart people work hard and hardworking people are also smart. Unfortunately, as they reach middle childhood, they begin to realize that effort alone may not lead to great achievement; one also needs ability. Adolescents are clear that effort is actually an indication of one's low ability. Smart people do not *need* to work hard. Those who do must not be very smart.⁵⁰ Middle-school and high-school children have been widely documented to use all sorts of strategies to hide their effort (not just to fend off peer harassment) in order to avoid being viewed as low in ability (mostly likely by teachers).⁵¹ Given the deep-seated nature of the talent assumption in the West, it is not hard to see how those who try to work hard to improve their achievement may be regarded as trying futilely to alter their "unalterable" lot. This is probably why the low-ability children were the first to take the brunt of their peers' harassment in Bishops' study. But it is also undeniable that the term *nerd*, along with its image, projects a pathetic air and consequent laughter in the listener. This is also likely the reason why those who manage to impress peers with "effortless perfection" are left alone.

I happen to know a boy who, in my view, offers an excellent illustration of how this talent assumption operates in school. In each of his high school English classes, his first essays would receive a B. His teachers were all highly qualified and caring and were always willing to help the boy. In ninth grade, this boy actually tried to do everything his teacher asked him to do such as writing an outline, drafting, and revising based on the teacher's suggestions. He still received a B. Being the inquisitive person he was, he began an experiment on himself. He deliberately did not submit his next essays on time, first just a few hours late, then one day late, and eventually several weeks late. When he did submit all of his work, he still received a B. In his sophomore and junior year, the same process repeated. This boy concluded that there was an unspoken ordinance at work here: once a student was labeled as a B-writer, there was no amount of good that he or she could do to change

the teacher's view. The most bizarre finding of his self-experimentation was that there was also no amount of bad that the B-writer could do to reduce him/her to a C-writer either. He was held in his slot, so to speak! Of course, most readers would agree that his boy was foolish to experiment with his own academic performance. That aside, it behooves us to look at how deep-rooted the fixed view of talent is on school ground. Needless to say, this boy no longer enjoys writing, even though he writes, in my judgment, quite well, certainly much better than I began writing in English.

On the scholarly front, Heyman, Fu, and Lee⁵² in a recent study explored European-American and Chinese late elementary school children's willingness or reluctance to disclose their achievement or failure to their peers. They found that European-American children disclosed their achievement only to peers who had similar achievement levels. They would not disclose their achievement to peers with higher or lower levels in fear that they would be regarded as bragging (if disclosed to lower achiever) or revealing their low ability (if disclosed to higher achiever, presumably fearing being viewed as stuck in their unalterably low slot).

Jeannie Oakes, a leading researcher on the American education system, conducted long and thorough investigations on the well-known high school tracking system. Her research provides the clear conclusion that high school education is not about improving children's learning but about confirming their exhibited ability. Oakes and Guiton write:

What made these recommendations and initial judgments [from junior high school teachers for placing ninth grades] so powerful was the widespread belief that a student's educational prospects are virtually set by the time he or she gets to high school. Many considered motivation and intellectual ability to be fixed attributes over which educators have little control. We found little evidence that educators at any of the schools thought that high schools courses could (or should even try to) increase students' intellectual capacities or raise their expectations. This theme echoed in the words of many administrators, teachers, and counselors.... Some told us directly that they felt that it was "all over" by high school. For example, [a] principal ... said that he could tell by the end of kindergarten which children would be successful in high school.... One counselor reported that high school teachers generally believe that, once a student gets to high school, he or she is either intrinsically motivated or not and this cannot be changed.⁵³

Given "the prevailing view that high school students' abilities are intractable,"⁵⁴ the purpose of curriculum and pedagogy is thus to accommodate what characteristics children already possess, but not to alter or

improve them. Although the researchers studied high school teachers and administrators' beliefs that underlay the tracking philosophy and practice, the researchers' report suggests that this kind of view is not limited to high school; kindergarten teachers can also cast the same kind of judgment on much younger children's ability.

Finally, there seems to be an assumption of the intellectual-social divide. If a child is interested in intellectual pursuits, something must be amiss with that child. The missing and hence wrong part is that the child must lack social competence and may not ever acquire it, as Feather's tall poppies were viewed. Putting aside the serious moral problem of harassing someone who lacks some competence (this is similar to the moral problem of harassing a handicapped person), this assumption of the intellectual-social divide is flat out wrong. Developmental research as well as the fast-advancing field of neuroscience tells us that all human beings (even those who are born with congenital challenges) possess the capacity to develop all human competence to a very high, albeit varying, degree. Every human being, if given the opportunity and support, can flourish with just about any skill.⁵⁵ Not only are we not doomed at birth; we have potentials that are rarely fully realized. A child who lacks any competence initially – be it intellectual, social, or even athletic – can acquire them when put in the right nurturing environment. But if the fixed-self/fixed-ability view (contrary to what is scientifically known) reigns in the school yard, the so-called nerds are bound to be created, who are, sadly, doomed to suffer cruel peer harassment.

THE EAST ASIAN LEARNER IN THE EYE OF THE PEERS

The school peer culture is quite different in East Asia. In Chinese culture, the strongest influence came, undoubtedly, from the Confucian learning tradition. Japan and Korea may be similar to Chinese culture in this regard, owing to the same influence. To begin with, the very term “school peer” in Chinese is *tongxue* (同學), made of two characters. The first means “together” and the second “learning”; “peers” are thus literally “those who learn together.” In Japanese, a more formal term 學友, also still used in Chinese written language, means “learning friends.” *Douryou* (同僚) or *nakama* (仲間) are more everyday terms but also used for peers at workplace. 同 in 同僚 is the same character as the first one in the Chinese common term 同學, and 仲間 means people in the same group who do activities together. In Korean, the term peer is *kyo-woo* (校友), meaning “school friends.” All of the terms in these three cultures have the shared characters, either “together” (同), “learn” (學), or “friend” (友).

The distinction between the Western concept of “peer” and East Asian terms is not trivial. According to Webster’s English dictionary, a “peer” is “one that is of equal standing with another, one belonging to the same societal group especially based on age, grade, or status.”⁵⁶ The key defining attribute is equal standing of age, grade, or status. Most highlighted is the idea of status in a group. The Chinese term *tongxue* is defined in the *New Dictionary of Modern Chinese Language* as “one that learns/studies with the same teacher and/or at the same school.”⁵⁷ Status such as age, grade, and standing is not part of the definition. What is highlighted is learning/studying together at the same place from the same teacher(s), and the relationship is that of friends. For the Western peer, the key importance is placed on the status/standing in a group of school-aged children, whereas in the East Asian terms, it is friends learning from the same teacher(s) or at the same place.⁵⁸

Significance of Learning Peers

How do Chinese *tongxues* (hereinafter the English term “peer” is used for convenience) regard and treat each other? From the very beginning, when Confucius first took his students, a peer is someone one studied with. Peers have the same goal of learning. As discussed in previous chapters, in Confucian persuasion, the goal is to follow a path to cultivate oneself morally. Despite a personal commitment to this process, the actual learning is not best achieved by oneself, contemplating and practicing self-cultivation alone. Peers are seen as essential in this learning process. Confucius’ *Analects* opens with the first sentence: “Having studied, to then repeatedly apply what you have learned – is this not a source of pleasure?” The very next sentence, also cast in the same delightful question, is “To have [like-minded] friends come from distant quarters [to study with oneself] – is this not a source of enjoyment?”⁵⁹ Thus, learning with peers who are pursuing the same moral goals was conceived of by Confucius as an enjoyment.

One’s peers are then not just strangers who happen to learn/study at the same time under the same mentor, but like-minded friends who pursue the same life goals. They are supporters of each other. The *Analects* records the following exchange between Confucius and Zigong, a pupil from a wealthy background who felt a need to show (off) his insight into human virtue when he no longer felt superior to the poor:

ZIGONG SAID: “What do you think of the saying: ‘Poor but not inferior; rich but not superior?’” The Master replied: “Not bad, but not as good as: ‘Poor but enjoying the way (*dao*, 道), rich but loving ritual propriety (*li*, 禮)’”

ZIGONG SAID: “*The Book of Songs* states:

Like bone carved and polished,

Like jade cut and ground.

Is this not what you have in mind?”

THE MASTER SAID: “Zigong, it is only with the likes of you then that I can discuss the *Songs*! On the basis of what has been said, you know what is yet to come.”⁶⁰

“Like bone carved and polished, like jade cut and ground” (*qiecuo zhuomo*, 切磋琢磨) is a verse of a poem in the *Book of Songs*⁶¹ from which Confucius and his pupils drew wisdom and aesthetic guidance. This poetic verse through Confucius’ teaching of Zigong has come to epitomize what learning peers do with each other in East Asia: studying, wondering, and discussing, helping, correcting, and above all, learning from and improving each other. There is no wonder why one’s learning peers are the major part of one’s life-long social circles beyond the family. One’s shared learning is also one’s shared living and shared growth, which is treasured dearly. Thus, the term *tongxue* in higher learning becomes *tongchuang*, shared study hall, and eventually may become *tongchuang haoyou*, good friends of a shared study hall. This basic regard of one’s learning peers has lasted through millennia to the present (as will be seen in late sections on research from East Asia). “Friends” are part of the formal Japanese and Chinese term 學友 and the Korean term 校友. In this cultural ethos, calling a learning friend a derogatory name and harassing such a friend is, to put it bluntly, quite unthinkable.

Nerd's Haven

The reader may be wondering if there are no peer problems in this kind of cultural context. To be sure, there is also a term *bookworm* (書呆子) to describe someone who does nothing but study books. However, this term is not often used for and by schoolchildren, but rather for and by adults. There may be other terms in these cultures to refer to unusual behaviors and styles. Certainly, peer isolation and rejection also occur in East Asia. Recently, there have been reports about increasing peer bullying in East Asian schools.⁶² But the important difference here is that peer unkindness has little to do with the target peer pursuing intellectual interests or being an excellent student. According to Xinyin Chen, an expert in Chinese children’s social development, there are only two peer groups in Chinese school yard, at least within Mainland China: the good student group and the antisocial/delinquent group. Nerd as a

type or a classification does not seem to exist (yet, there are many more peer groups in the West such as the jocks, geeks, brainies, goths, stoners, druggies, etc.).⁶³

Quite the contrary, those who achieve highly are generally admired, popular, emulated, and sought after as friends regardless of whether these high achievers are “uncool” otherwise (e.g., appearance, athletic ability, and purely social prowess). Good learning alone is reason for peer respect and admiration. In my study on Chinese ideal learners, the respondents were asked to describe how the learners’ peers would regard them; 87 percent wrote respect and admiration and 42 percent acknowledging them as role models and desiring their friendship.⁶⁴ Huang’s research on why Taiwanese children are willing to attend the so-called cram schools also found that gaining peer respect was one of the top reasons.⁶⁵ The study my colleague and I conducted on kindergartners’ perceptions of high-achieving peers also showed that Chinese children desired to be like the high achievers and to emulate them (but European-American children perceived more peer rejection and isolation toward the high achievers).⁶⁶ Most recent research⁶⁷ on how peer groups function in Chinese schools found that elementary school and middle-school children belonging to high-achieving groups become more socially competent two years later. On the other hand, high social competence alone did not have the reverse effect – that is, it did not make children achieve better academically during the same period of time – countering the theory and research on Western children’s group functions.⁶⁸ Furthermore, even academically weaker students who belonged to high-achieving groups developed fewer social problems than children who belonged to low-achieving groups. Associating oneself with high-achieving peers in China has protective power against developing negative social behaviors. These studies confirm that in China, good learning does indeed bring peer respect and liking and other positive benefits. The otherwise persecuted “nerds” may flourish in such a protective haven.

In the domain of learning, the peer culture in China, unlike that in the West, is more or less in harmony with the culture of school, family, and society at large. In other words, although youth in East Asia also have their own music, fashion, group activities, and online sites, and generational gaps and clashes also exist, their culture seems to have less conflict between school and family when it comes to school learning. How does such a peer culture operate? There are at least three discernable levels that interact with each other to produce such a peer culture: school/community, family, and children themselves.

Peer Supported Learning in School and Community

Within school, students who achieve highly are often identified by the school as the leaders of their classes, and such leaders obtain this role not necessarily because of their marvelous personality traits (e.g., outgoing, gregarious, friendly, physically attractive), but serve the central role of modeling for the rest of children. That is, these students are held as model students for others to emulate. In China, for example, schools annually select the so-called Students with Three Excellences (三好学生): in moral conduct, academic achievement, and artistic/athletic achievement. Teachers and peers nominate and vote for such students. The idea behind setting up model students is that everyone should learn and is capable of learning from the exemplars and achieving the same level as them. At the present time, schools adopt a more democratic process as a method to select student leaders. For example, nominees conduct campaigns where they engage in debates with their opponents and present their ideas for how they would like to work for their classes and grades. Peers then cast their votes, and the votes are announced and counted publicly. Regardless of the selecting methods, no student is likely to be chosen as a model student without academic excellence. Excellence in social relations and extracurricular achievements alone is not admired as much as academic excellence.⁶⁹

Once chosen, it is regarded a high honor in school. To achieve a positive effect on the peers, schools may routinely organize workshops where high-achieving students share their personal challenges and strategies they used to overcome such difficulties. They offer tips on how to approach various school subjects, how they balance social and other extracurricular activities with learning tasks, and how they approach studying. Peers ask questions and exchange ideas. When such workshops are held, all children attend them. As discussed previously, high achievers do not necessarily feel uncomfortable in the spotlight because they are not believed to possess some inherent ability and special talent at birth, but rather skills that they have acquired. Likewise, those who do not achieve highly are not regarded as lacking inherent ability either. All children stand to benefit from learning how to achieve better from those model students. Indeed, different students may be put on the pedestal in different years.

Other than these kinds of workshops, higher-achieving students are openly “charged” by teachers to help their peers. For each subject, there is one subject representative (科代表). Teachers urge students to seek such subject representatives and other high-achieving students. Meanwhile, lower-achieving students are encouraged to seek help from their peers.

The helpers and help seekers work quite seamlessly in class. Teachers even pair high-achieving students with low-achieving students one on one in order to raise achievement for everyone (teachers have an incentive to do so given that their promotion depends, in part, on how their entire classes achieve). A teacher in Beijing gives a vivid illustration of how this kind of peer-supported learning takes place:

An 8th grade student was very shy and quiet in class. Every time the teacher called on him to answer a question, he would not say anything, hanging his head and blushing. His classmates would mumble to the teacher to not bother him because “he didn’t know.” But the teacher soon discovered that the boy was very good at math. She told the class that whoever could make this boy talk would get extra credit for the course. Many peers approached the boy.... Now he is not afraid of talking in class, and he interacts well with his peers.⁷⁰

It is quite clear that both the helpers and the help recipient have a mutual understanding that a student can improve, and nothing is shameful about getting help and nothing is inappropriate about offering help in this cultural context.

Recent research on how older elementary school children disclosed their achievement to peers provides a good glimpse into this process. As cited previously, Heyman and colleagues⁷¹ found that European-American schoolchildren would only disclose their achievement to peers who have similar achievement levels, but they would not disclose their achievement to peers with higher or lower levels in fear that they would be regarded as bragging (if disclosed to lower achievers, likely fearing peer sanction for high achievement) or revealing their low ability (if disclosed to higher achievers). However, Chinese schoolchildren would disclose their own achievement to all peers regardless of their levels. If disclosed to a higher achiever, the disclosing peer is regarded as eliciting help from the higher achiever, and help is on the way. If it is disclosed to a lower achiever, the disclosing peer is regarded as offering help, and the lower achiever would be grateful for such help. These findings make good sense given how common peer-supported learning is in Chinese schools.

A more routine way to ensure such peer-supported learning is through the so-called small groups (小组). Chinese schools have large classes (forty for elementary school and sixty or more students per class for middle school and high school). However, each class is organized into small groups by seating arrangement. A sixty-student class may have six or fewer small groups. Often, small-group leaders are elected by group members, but

many schools encourage students to take turns assuming the role of small-group leaders so that all children get a chance to develop leadership skills. Small-group leaders help teachers with their teaching such as distributing and collecting student work and quizzes, organizing group extracurricular activities, communicating on behalf of the class, and assigning cleaning jobs (Chinese children clean their own schools).

Other than these organizational tasks, small-group leaders ensure learning among group members. For example, they work together to complete their homework. Chinese and other East Asian children are assigned a much heavier load of homework each day than Western children.⁷² Homework completion is required and checked by teachers carefully, with feedback. However, unlike in the West, homework is *not* graded as part of the student achievement record. Then why is homework assigned at all? And why so much? Homework is meant to serve the purpose of practicing, reviewing, and gaining new insight into the material taught during the day, not to demonstrate mastery per se, because mastery is believed to be acquired over time, as detailed in [Chapter 4](#). Again, this design and use of homework is reflective of the Confucian principal of deeper learning through review and gaining new insight. Thus, homework is a learning process, not time and opportunity to show one's mastery.⁷³

Frequently, the members of small groups may take turns to organize homework times at school or to invite peers to their homes. As a middle-school student, I brought in peers (not my personal friends) to my home. After dinner, my parents would clean the dinner table, and the children would do homework together. Group homework serves two significant learning goals: (1) ensuring that everyone completes homework and (2) helping each other digest what was taught during the day. Those who understood, say, a math concept would explain it to those who were struggling with it. At the end of the study group, all group members had something to gain. There are two important additional benefits of group homework: (3) reducing the otherwise impossible teaching load of the teachers and (4) fostering positive peer relationships. Finally, parents may not need to be highly knowledgeable of subject matter and intensively involved in the day-to-day learning and peer interactions of their children (as is the case in the West, where parents need to make play dates, drive children to different extracurricular programs, and help them do homework). Children are naturally involved with and for each other.

High-achieving students are not kept secret inside school but publicized across local communities through the media, as is done in the West. There are different levels of honor students – school, district, city, and

provincial – with the three excellences. The higher the level, the greater the honor.⁷⁴ Communities take great pride in having highly achieving students. In 2005, I visited several cities and local towns in China and saw banners hanging across the roads and streets of towns, proudly announcing the top students in that year's college entrance examination. In the town's centers, businesses posted boards on the street, stating their donation levels to students for various ranks of college admissions. Apparently, this tradition continues abroad. In America, for example, Chinese-language newspapers also routinely print the profiles of winners of national, state, and local scholastic competitions.⁷⁵ It would be difficult, if not nearly impossible, to counter such a cultural ethos.

Peers as Role Models through Parents

Parents play a major role in further strengthening positive attitudes toward high-achieving peers. Parents in any culture are the key bearers of their cultural values because they socialize their children accordingly. Although parents are active promoters of their cultural values, they do so often without awareness of their own role. This interesting process is understood as *enculturation* by which people acquire the values of their cultures through participation in daily life. The power and success of enculturation lies, as anthropologists have long recognized, in the very mundane living in the culture, which does not require formal education. Chinese children's positive attitude toward their high-achieving peers has much to do with this kind of parenting process. Apparently, Chinese (and other East Asian) parents routinely engage in identifying model students for their own children and in ensuring that their children actually learn from them.

First, as noted in [Chapter 4](#), Chinese culture has a long tradition of using models for teaching the young. All great scholars and learning models throughout Chinese history continue to live in oral tales, with many noted in the village records, the town's public monuments, as well as rendered in movies and dramas.⁷⁶ In school, children read these stories as part of learning the Chinese language. I examined the Chinese-language curriculum for China's nine-year compulsory education, which is still largely centralized in China, and found that 36 percent of the learning material contained these learner models.⁷⁷ Because the current students' parents learned these stories in their own childhood, these role models are equally alive for parents and students. To motivate their children, parents routinely cite these models (in concert with teachers' citations) and urge their children to emulate

these models. Hence, children are familiar with and used to this style of parenting.

But parents do more than just rely on historical figures and distant high achievers. Parents are also active seekers of good students in the neighborhood. They frequently talk to their children's friends to find out who among their peers does better at school. These good students include relatives, children of their friends and coworkers, and otherwise acknowledged good students in the community. Once parents discover such models, they refer their own children to them often, in clear comparative terms, urging their children to emulate these models. My personal example is a case in point. When I received my doctoral degree from my university in the United States, my mother sent the photos of my robing ceremony to relatives in China. Unbeknownst to me, several of my relatives in China had the photos framed and hung them on their living rooms' walls. Their family pride aside, I became, apparently, a role model in their eyes. They used this model to motivate their own children to learn better. In our study on Chinese immigrant high school students, 77 percent of them reported that their parents used good students from their neighborhood as role models. Surprisingly, despite the fact that many found their parents' effort annoying, these Chinese immigrant adolescents acknowledged that their parents' citations of higher-achieving students made them motivated to work harder. The following excerpt from an interview with a student illustrates this parenting effort: "[M]y mother, she likes to brag about me for some reason, and then she . . . sees someone else's report card for some reason . . . and then she's like, look at this kid, she got all A's. And look at you, you got one B . . . you're supposed to have more A's. And I'm like, isn't that enough? . . . Well, I wouldn't say demoralize, I would say that it would motivate me a little bit more . . . to work harder."⁷⁸ Whereas it is common among Chinese parents, this kind of model use as a motivational strategy for their children is rarely observed among European-American and other ethnic parents.

Children Seek Peer-Supported Learning on Their Own

Given the general attitude toward high-achieving peers, it is only natural for Chinese children to have similar attitudes toward such peers. In my study on model learners, I also asked college students to respond to the question "how would your model learner feel toward those who have a strong heart and mind for learning (好學心)?" The majority (77 percent) wrote that the model learner would respect, admire, revere, esteem, and appreciate those who have such love for learning. Forty-two percent stated that the model

learner would humbly learn from, be motivated to catch up with, take the model learner as his/her own example, and strive to improve themselves further. Forty-three percent acknowledged that model learners would find such people to be their soul mates, to share the same life goals, to desire to become like, or to be friends with.⁷⁹ Recent research on ordinary Chinese elementary school children, not ideal learners, by Heyman and associates and Chen and associates provide support for this very awareness of peer paragons.⁸⁰

Thus, peers seek each other out even without the nudging from teachers and parents. In a study that my colleagues and I conducted, we found that Chinese immigrant high school students from low-income backgrounds continued to use this peer-supported learning to help each other in school. When we asked them who helps them with their homework, one-third said that they do homework with their friends either at school or at each other's places, because their parents had neither English proficiency nor American curricular knowledge to help them. These children had to depend on themselves, but they chose to use peer-supported learning rather than individual learning. For example, one peer might be better at math, and he would explain math concepts to the group. Another peer might have a better understanding of history, and she would look up the information online and help the group. Because of the advent of instant messaging technology, sometimes the group may not gather in one physical location but work online, doing homework together in real time. Such peer-supported learning was rarely mentioned by the other ethnic groups, including those from European-American background.

Deep Roots for Honoring High Achievers in East Asia

The preceding sections present a clear picture: Not only do high-achieving students suffer little peer harassment, but they are actually honored and upheld as role models in East Asia. What schools, communities, parents, and children themselves do to create a haven for learning in school is the first-order examination. However, the description of the reality and how it operates does not get to the question of why the culture is so different. In what follows, I attempt to outline, based on research, some underlying values and beliefs that are important for understanding the existence and continuation of such a peer culture for learning in East Asia.

First, as discussed previously, East Asian students inherit a cultural learning tradition that has been shaping children's lives and their education systems for millennia. Throughout history, there has been very little

interruption of this tradition except for the ten years of Mainland Chinese official denunciation of learning from 1966 to 1976.⁸¹ Ironically, even that unfortunate political downturn did not altogether eradicate Chinese people's desire for learning (although intellectuals were persecuted). What was truly denounced was particular knowledge, namely Confucian learning along with learning of science and other "bourgeois" material. Soon after the "catastrophe of ten years" (十年浩劫), learning of everything resumed with renewed energy and dedication. Except for China, other East Asian cultures have not experienced any notable discontinuity. Thus, it is not overstating that this tradition has been deeply entrenched in East Asia, with no sign of abating. Such a value system is not easily subject to any peer counterculture.

Second, a peer counterculture against high achieving has to have a clear cause. There is none, however, in my judgment. Why would children revolt against something that their parents and they themselves desire and regard as important? Besides, schools, communities, and families create conditions under which low- and average-achieving students have frequent interactions with high-achieving students to receive help and to self-improve. It makes little sense for peers to invent derogatory names to torment their helpers.

But a deeper reason for high achievers' haven is that East Asia does not hold the view that the self is fixed and likewise that one's ability is more or less determined at birth. Unlike in the West, the self in East Asia is regarded as malleable⁸² through personal effort and social influence. As discussed before, personal commitment (along with the learning virtues) holds the key to personal development including the growth of one's ability and intelligence. Hence, if a person does well on a task, the self is not implicated as wholly positive; rather, the self is regarded as still changeable in any direction. Likewise, if the person fails, it does not implicate anything inherently negative in the person. Because life-long learning is taken as a fundamental life course for anyone, the self is expected and encouraged to improve regardless of how much one has achieved or failed. Of utmost importance is that the person is willing and actually makes an effort to self-improve.⁸³

Belief in social influence is the second part of how the self may be subject to considerable change, which is an extension of the view that the self is malleable. Chinese culture strongly emphasizes the influence of the environment in child development.⁸⁴ Teachers, parents, and children use a common expression that epitomizes the general belief about one's potential to be influenced by others: "near cinnabar, one becomes red; near pitch, one becomes black" (近朱者赤,近墨者黑). The younger the child, the more

changeable he or she is by the environment. Parents and teachers urge their children to be near good influence and stay away from not-so-good influence. That children are encouraged by teachers and parents to seek high-achieving students out for help is a direct reflection of this cultural belief. Upon discovery that their children have friends who display questionable behaviors such as not wanting to learn or delinquency, parents discourage their children from interactions with such peers. Given that good learning also signals good virtues and morals in Chinese culture, it is sensible for Chinese parents to promote their children's friendship with high achievers.⁸⁵

Recent research on cultural variations between Western and East Asian people shows that East Asians perceive and think about objects very differently.⁸⁶ Whereas Western people focus on the object itself, East Asian people attend to a larger purview of the environment, the background. When given a group of the same objects, such as a number of identical red pencils and a single object that is different from the group, say, a green pencil, or a big fish in a group of small fish, Western people see the single object as standing out, unique, and so forth. But East Asians attend to the group of objects more. This tendency is taken by some researchers as indicative of their culturally influenced focus, awareness, and information processing. Most recent research⁸⁷ also documents that Asian children as young as three years of age are more likely to be influenced by adult consensus than their European-American peers. Although these lab experiments focus purportedly on cognitive differences between the two cultural groups, I would argue that East Asian people's attentiveness to the environment (i.e., factors other than oneself) provides support for their fundamental belief in "near cinnabar, one becomes red; near pitch, one becomes black," which underlies their effort to socialize their children toward desirable developmental outcomes.

A related explanation of the cultural differences in peer culture comes from Márta Fülöp's research on cultural difference in competition, as noted previously.⁸⁸ Fülöp started with the assumption that competition and cooperation are conceptualized in the West as the mutually exclusive dichotomy in people's behavior. According to this view, if a culture is high on competition, it is necessarily low on cooperation. The United States is a highly competitive culture, low on cooperation, because of its emphasis on individualism; by contrast, formerly socialist Hungary was a case of high cooperation but low competition (presumably because of their socialist rule). Yet, Japan poses challenges to this Western dichotomous view because Japan is both high in competition and cooperation. To find out

how high competition and cooperation could coexist, Fülöp studied more than 700 high school students in these three cultures. She asked each student to describe how prevalent competition was in their school, how they viewed competition, and how they engaged in competition themselves.

She found that Japanese students reported the most competition in school, followed by the American students. Hungarian students reported the least competition. Examples students gave ranged from trying to get better grades, to win contests, to excel on entrance exams, to try to get into better colleges in academics, as well as to engage in extracurricular activities. However, despite the greatest prevalence of competition reported by Japanese students, they experienced competition most positively. American students had the lowest positive experience, with Hungarian students in the middle. More Japanese students regarded competition as a process of self-improvement, motivation, personal effort, achievement, exercising their willpower, self-evaluation, and joy. The category that American students acknowledged most was that competition enabled them to push themselves to be their best. Hungarian students mentioned ranking among students most frequently. On the negative side of competition, American students reported the highest levels of stress, losing, and feeling selfish. Both American and Hungarian students also experienced a higher level of conflict with peers than Japanese students. Fülöp concludes that Japanese students' experience with competition in school is most positive, American most negative, and Hungarian falling in the middle. Japanese students engage in competition to motivate each other and to help each other improve. Hungarian students seek to raise their rank among their peers, and American students try to be the best. For Japanese students, rivals are friends, and the degree of cooperation is high, which results in improved achievement for everyone. Their relationships are strengthened. For Hungarian students, rivals are enemies, and the degree of cooperation is low,⁸⁹ which results in winners versus losers and consequently deteriorated relationships. For American students, rivals are opponents to win against, and the degree of cooperation is also low, but relationships may not matter to begin with.

Most recently, Watkins and his graduate students adopted Fülöp's method to study high school students' perception and engagement in competition in Hong Kong (in both high-ability and low/average-ability schools as tracked in Hong Kong).⁹⁰ Similar to Fülöp's findings, the majority of the participants in both kinds of schools reported that their schools encouraged them to compete with other students (81 percent and 67 percent among the two respective groups of students). However, students felt more positive

than negative or neutral about competition. Positive examples of student experience include:

1. Competition encourages me to improve myself; the feeling is quite good.
2. Competition motivates us to actively participate.
3. Through competition, our school encourages us to learn from each other.
4. I feel very happy because in competition all of us improve.

Some statements about negative experiences are:

1. Competition is hard work. I am unable to breathe and want to give up.
2. Very hard, very great pressure. I do not want to compete with others.
3. I feel nervous and I am desperate to win.

Furthermore, the researchers also asked students specifically whether they respected their opponents in study and sports. They found that the great majority (more than 90 percent) said yes, and the predominant reason was that their opponents were their “friends or classmates” and that the competitors should “respect everyone all the time.”

These studies compel us to conclude that learning and achieving are for everyone. These findings cohere with the basic Confucian tenet that peers in learning are people for one to learn from, to work with, to respect, and, most important of all, to enhance each other. In such a culture, “nerd” harassment has, so to speak, no home.

Then how do we explain the common observation that those who emerge on the top are the “nails that will be hammered down,” a common phenomenon in East Asia, much like the tall poppies?⁹¹ I would argue that the observation is not wrong, but it is an observation blindly and inappropriately applied to all domains of life. In East Asian social life, particularly in the domains where socioeconomic resource distribution is at stake, those who claim more resources may be subject to the hammering-down destiny. But improving oneself in learning with the goal of cultivating one’s virtuous and moral self is an entirely different thing. Self-striving to be virtuous and moral is not claiming more resources because virtuous and moral achievement is within reach of each person. And the more people in a society achieve the virtuous and moral goals, the better the society is as a whole. In this domain, the tall poppy is not only not a problem, but actually becomes a goal for everyone, especially when everyone is believed capable of becoming a tall poppy.

The final cultural value that explains the East Asian peer culture in learning, I would argue, has to do with the way social relationships are formed and maintained. Again, based on Confucianism, the most significant social relationships are formed at home. The family model serves as the lens through which the social world for the Chinese (and other East Asians) is conceptualized, classified, approached, and lived. Accordingly, children are taught at home to call their older siblings as either “older brother” (*gege*, 哥哥) or “older sister” (*jiejie*, 姐姐) and likewise to call their younger siblings “younger brother” (*didi*, 弟弟) and “younger sister” (*meimei*, 妹妹). Siblings are not usually called by their first names. All kin members have designated addresses by paternal or maternal (male/female) division, generation, and age. This model is also used to classify strangers, and children are taught this classification and approach social relations accordingly. For example, when meeting a neighborhood peer, the child needs to know if the peer is older or younger. If he is older, then the child will call him “older brother”; if the peer is younger, he will be called “younger brother.” Similarly, when meeting an unfamiliar male adult, the child also needs to know if the adult is older or younger than his or her father. If he is older, then the child will call him “older uncle” (*bobo*, 伯伯), and if he is younger, then “younger uncle” (*shushu*, 叔叔), or if dealing with females (*ayi*, 阿姨).⁹²

The most important purpose of this type of family extension to strangers is that all these roles by different addresses come with well-defined responsibilities/duties as well as care/privileges. For example, anyone that is addressed with “older” assumes a responsibility to care for, to instruct, to model, and to guide anyone addressed with “younger” by generation and by age. Even a slightly older sibling is asked by parents to show her younger sibling better behavior (e.g., yielding a candy to the younger), and this type of socialization can be observed by children from different families playing together, where the mother will reason with an older child by appealing to the age differential (e.g., “you are the older sister, and she is the younger sister, so please give your toy for her to play with”). Anyone addressed with “younger” also accepts the stance to respect/honor, to listen to, and to follow the “older” person’s care, teaching, and guidance (e.g., a four-year-old child may be asked to look at what her six-year-old brother did in spelling and to emulate him). By the time they enter school, most Chinese children are familiar with this complex and finely differentiating system of address (at least for their immediate kin). Most children also have some sense of the responsibility/charge of those “older” people versus their own role as the “younger.”⁹³

Thus, children in Taiwan still address their peers with “learning older brother” (*xuezhang*, 學長), “learning younger brother” (*xuedi*, 學弟), “learning older sister” (*xuejie*, 學姐), and “learning younger sister” (*xuemei*, 學妹). When a younger peer comes to ask a question about a math problem, for example, the older learning peer will bear the responsibility to help the younger one. Likewise, when an older learning sister offers help or instructs the younger peer, the younger will accept this older peer’s guidance. This cultural system lends itself to the teacher and parental requests for high-achieving students to assume more responsibility for helping the low- and average-achieving students. Likewise, it is the duty expected of the low- and average-achieving students to seek help from the high-achieving students. No shame and contempt are involved in this learning system. Those who seek help are regarded as displaying the virtue of humility, and those who offer help are regarded as displaying the virtue of generosity and responsibility, as discussed in previous chapters. This type of social relationship based on the family model makes it harder for peers to engage in “nerd” harassment.⁹⁴

Asian-American Children as the “Nerd” Group

At least among Asian Americans, it has been widely known that their children have been called nerds and harassed routinely in school. This is not surprising given the cultural background they come from, the open emphasis on school learning, and the generally higher achievement associated with them. What makes matters worse is that Asian children have a smaller physique and are sometimes less impressive in the athletic prowess than their counterparts from other ethnic groups. Both physically and behaviorally they fit the image of a “nerd.” Whereas other groups may have individual children suffering from the nerd-calling peer culture, Asian-American children as a whole are America’s default “nerd” group.

As such, they bear the brunt of peer harassment from all sides. My son’s experience is a case in point. On the national scene, the current lawsuit in Philadelphia filed by the Asian American Legal Defense and Education Fund against the school district for not protecting Asian-American students attests to the new height of peer harassment against the Asian “nerds.” According to NBC news, twenty-six students were attacked by their non-Asian peers (beaten up, with thirteen students sent to the hospital, one with a broken nose).⁹⁵

The best-documented peer harassment against Asian-American students came from the research done by Niobe Way and associates

at New York University. In 2004, Susan Rosenbloom and Niobe Way⁹⁶ conducted an in-depth qualitative study over a two-year period. They interviewed Chinese immigrant youth attending diverse public schools in New York City. They also conducted school observations. They found widespread peer discrimination and peer victimization as experienced by Chinese adolescents from their non-Asian peers (twenty-six incidents of physical and verbal attacks against Chinese, but only one and three against African-American and Latino peers, respectively, during the same period). The following excerpts from their report provide details of such peer attacks:

A Chinese girl reported “The people in the school, they call me chino, stupid, or geek, or anything like that because I’m Chinese.”

Participant observation and the interviews revealed numerous incidences of physical harassment of the Asian American students by the non-Asian American students in school. Students reported random “slappings” by male and female peers as they walked through the hallways. Slappings are quick, pop shots often to the head or body as students passed one another in the hall or anywhere else. Asian American students described them as unnerving, randomly occurring, and humiliating violations that are particularly harrowing for the boys when girls slap them.

Along with slappings, Asian American students were observed and reported being pushed, punched, teased, and mocked by their non-Asian American peers. The racial slur “chino” or “geek” was often heard as Asian American students passed by. The physical and verbal harassment of the Asian American students occurred when adults were present and when they were not.

Kit Wah told the interviewer that a male Asian American friend was held up with a knife in the gym locker room by a student in his class. His friend was robbed of several items.

Incidents such as these that included having money, jewelry, and jackets stolen are typical events that Asian American students described when discussing how they were victimized for being Asian American in school.... Asian American students appeared to be more frequently targeted for robbery. These events seemed to be a part of the normalized landscape of behaviors that Asian American students endured in this school.

Niobe Way⁹⁷ in a subsequent paper states that such peer harassment against Asian-American children by non-Asian peers is not limited to New York City, but is a common problem across the United States.

In a recent study, Desirée Qin, Niobe Way, and Preetika Mukherjee⁹⁸ interviewed Chinese immigrant youth aged from nine to fourteen in both New York City and Boston. They reported a similar finding but also clear reasons for such peer discrimination from non-Asian peers: the perception that Chinese children were high achievers and that teachers give Asian-American students preferential treatment.

Finally, Deborah Rivas-Drake, Diane Hughes, and Niobe Way used standard measures of peer discrimination to study how that predicts early adolescents' psychological well-being. They found that compared to African Americans, Chinese-American students reported nearly twice as many peer harassment incidents, higher depressive symptoms, and lower self-esteem. All of these differences were statistically significant. The researchers concluded that "Chinese American early adolescents ... reported feeling that they are treated badly, unfairly, teased, harassed, and called names by peers, who are individuals whom they encounter on a regular basis."⁹⁹

Asian-American children who try to do what they are supposed to do in American school – that is, learning and achieving well – face very harsh peer problems regularly. I hope this chapter has provided some insights into the cultural roots of this harassment. But regardless of the root causes, this reality is truly hell for many Asian-American children.

NOTES

1. See note 11 to Chapter 4.
2. See Perner, J., Leekam, S. R., & Wimmer, H. (1987). Three year olds difficulty with false belief: The case for a conceptual deficit. *British Journal of Developmental Psychology*, 5(2), 125–137; Astington, J. W. (1993). *The child's discovery of the mind*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; and Wellman, H. M., Cross, D., & Watson, J. (2001). Meta-analysis of theory of mind development: The truth about false beliefs. *Child Development*, 72, 655–684 for research on children's social cognitive development.
3. See note 11 to Chapter 4.
4. Wentzel, K. R., & Caldwell, K. (1997). Friendships, peer acceptance, and group membership: Relations to academic achievement in middle school. *Child Development*, 68, 1198–1209; Wentzel, K. R., & Wigfield, A. (1998). Academic and social motivational influence on students' academic performance. *Educational Psychology Review*, 10(2), 155–175; Uguroglu, M. E., & Walberg, H. J. (1986). Predicting achievement and motivation. *Journal of Research and Development in Education*, 19, 1–12; and Kindermann, T. (1993). Natural peer groups as contexts for individual development: The case of children's motivation in school. *Developmental Psychology*, 29, 970–977.
5. Wentzel, K. R., & Asher, S. R. (1995). The academic lives of neglected, rejected, popular, and controversial children. *Child Development*, 66, 754–763.

6. Ladd, G. W., & Troop-Gordon, W. (2003). The role of chronic peer difficulties in the development of children's psychological adjustment problems. *Child Development*, 74(5), 1344–1367.
7. Feather, N. T. (1989). Attitudes towards the high achiever: The fall of the tall poppy. *Australian Journal of Psychology*, 41(3), 239–267; Boehnke, K. (2008). Peer pressure: a cause of scholastic underachievement? A cross-cultural study of mathematical achievement among German, Canadian, and Israeli middle-school students. *Social Psychology of Education*, 11(2), 149–160; and Bishop, J. H., & Bishop, M. M. (2008). An economic theory of academic engagement norms: The struggle for popularity and normative hegemony in secondary schools. Unpublished manuscript.
8. Fülöp, M. (1999). Students' perception of the role of competition in their respective countries: Hungary, Japan, and the USA. In A. Ross, *Young citizens in Europe* (pp. 195–219). London: University of North London.
9. Asher, S. R., & Coie, J. D. (Eds.) (1990). *Peer rejection in childhood*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
10. Pellegrini, A. D., & Long, J. D. (2003). A longitudinal study of bullying, dominance, and victimization during the transition from primary through secondary school. *British Journal of Developmental Psychology*, 20, 259–280.
11. See note 5 to this chapter.
12. See note 11 to Chapter 4, and Nishina, A., & Juvonen, J. (2005). Daily reports of witnessing and experiencing peer harassment in middle school. *Child Development*, 76(2), 435–450.
13. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter.
14. See Elliott, J. G., Hufton, N. R., Illushin, L., & Willis, W. (2005). *Motivation, engagement, and educational performance: International perspectives on the contexts of learning*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan for discussion of swot (pp. 122–123); see the second reference in note 7 to this chapter for German *Schreber* and Hebrew *hnun*.
15. Personal communication with Marie Suizzo for French *bouttoneux*.
16. Personal communication with Marieke van Egmond for Dutch *stuud*.
17. See note 14 to this chapter.
18. For convenience, I use *nerd* or *nerds* instead of naming all other similar terms to discuss this phenomenon.
19. Seuss, G. T. (1950). *If I ran the zoo*. New York: Random House.
20. Nugent, B. (2007, July 29). Who's a nerd, anyway? *New York Times Magazine*. Retrieved July 28, 2007 from http://www.nytimes.com/2007/07/29/magazine/29wwln-idealab-t.html?_r=1&ref=magazine&oref=slogin
21. *American heritage dictionary of the English language* (3rd ed.). (1992). New York: Houghton Mifflin, p. 1212.
22. See Fordham, S., & Ogbu, J. U. (1986). Black students' school success: Coping with the "Burden of 'Acting White.'" *The Urban Review*, 18, 176–206 for similar problems with African-American schoolchildren.
23. White, S. H. (1998). What do we have to do to create a better social design for adolescence? Paper read in honor of TheodoreSizer at Brown University.
24. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter; and Juvonen, J., & Gross, E. F. (2005). The rejected and the bullied: Lessons about social misfits from

- developmental psychology. In W. D. Kipling, J. P. Forgas, & W. von Hippel (Eds.), *The social outcast: Ostracism, social exclusion, rejection, and bullying* (pp. 155–170). New York: Psychology Press.
25. See the first reference in note 7 to this chapter.
 26. See the first reference in note 7 to this chapter, p. 256.
 27. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter.
 28. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter, p. 22.
 29. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter, p. 12.
 30. See Nicholls, J. G. (1978). The development of the concepts of effort and ability, perception of academic attainment, and the understanding that difficult tasks require more ability. *Child Development*, 49, 800–814 for research on how New Zealand children's view of ability and effort changes from kindergarten to adolescence. Also see the second reference in note 16 to Chapter 5 for Dweck and Leggett's review of research on this topic.
 31. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter, pp. 14–15.
 32. Juvonen, J., & Murdock, T. B. (1995). Grade-level differences in the social value of effort: Implications for self-presentation tactics of early adolescents. *Child Development*, 66(6), 1694–1705.
 33. See the second reference in note 7 to this chapter.
 34. See the third reference in note 7 to this chapter.
 35. Fisher, C. B., Wallace, S. A., & Fenton, R. E. (2000). Discrimination distress during adolescence. *Journal of Youth & Adolescence*, 29, 679–695; Greene, M. L., Way, N., & Pahl, K. (2006). Trajectories of perceived adult and peer discrimination among Black, Latino, and Asian American adolescents: Patterns and psychological correlates. *Developmental Psychology*, 42(2), 218–238; La Greca, A. M., & Harrison, H. M. (2005). Adolescent peer relations, friendships, and romantic relationships: Do they predict social anxiety and depression? *Journal of Clinical Child & Adolescent Psychology*, 34, 49–61; Storch, E. A., & Masia-Warner, C. (2004). The relationship of peer victimization to social anxiety and loneliness in adolescent females. *Journal of Adolescence*, 27, 351–362; and Rivas-Drake, D., Hughes, D., & Way, N. (2008). A closer look at peer discrimination, ethnic identity, and psychological well-being among urban Chinese American sixth graders. *Journal of Youth and Adolescence*, 37, 12–21.
 36. See note 11 to Chapter 4.
 37. See the second reference in note 6 to Chapter 3.
 38. Indeed, his new school, the Wheeler School in Providence in Rhode Island, was attended mostly by children who were motivated, serious learners. High achievement was expected and celebrated and was a school pride. Both our son and we are grateful to the school for promoting the right values and for creating a safe learning environment for children.
 39. Strayer, F. F. (1991). The development of agonistic and affiliative structures in preschool play groups. In J. Silverberg & P. Gray (Eds.), *To fight or not to fight: Violence and peacefulness in humans and other primates*. Oxford: Oxford University Press; and Fiske, A. P., & Haslam, N. (2005). The four basic social bonds: Structures for coordinating interaction. In M. W. Baldwin (Ed.), *Interpersonal cognition* (pp. 267–298). New York: Guilford.

40. See Arnett, J. J. (2008). The neglected 95%: Why American psychology needs to become less American. *American Psychologist*, 63(7), 602–614 for discussion of this problem.
41. See Chen, X.-Y., & French, D. C. (2008). Children's social competence in cultural context. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 59, 591–616 for a review of cross-cultural research.
42. See note 81 to Chapter 3 and note 19 to Chapter 5.
43. See Fischer, H. A., Manstead, A. S. R., & Rodriguez Mosquera, P. M. (1999). The role of honor-related vs. individualist values in conceptualizing pride, shame, and anger: Spanish and Dutch cultural prototypes. *Cognition & Emotion*, 13(2), 149–179 for an example.
44. See notes 26 and 28 to Chapter 5.
45. Tesser, A., Campbell, J., & Smith, M. (1984). Friendship choice and performance: Self-evaluation maintenance in children. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 46(3), 561–574; and Ruble, D. N., Frey, K. S., & Greulich, F. (1995). Meeting goals and confronting conflicts: Children's changing perceptions of social comparison. *Child Development*, 66, 723–738.
46. See note 8 to this chapter.
47. See the classic Galton, F. (1869/2006). *Hereditary genius: An inquiry into its laws and consequences*. Amherst, NY: Prometheus and its recent reincarnation; Herrnstein, R. J., & Murray, C. (1994). *The bell curve*. Chicago: Free Press.
48. See Steenbergen-Hu, S.-Y., & Moon, S. M. (2011). The effects of acceleration on high-ability learners: A meta-analysis. *Gifted Child Quarterly*, 55(1), 39–53 for an example of research on this topic. The fact that the West has the term *gifted children* and a whole journal devoted to research on such children indicates the importance of the concept “talent” and born intellectual “gift” in children. Also see Winner, E. (1996). *Gifted children: Myths and realities*. New York: Basic Books for more discussions.
49. See the second reference in note 16 to Chapter 5; and Dweck, C. S. (1999). *Self-theories*. Philadelphia: Psychology Press.
50. See the first reference in note 30 to this chapter and note 32 to this chapter.
51. See Covington, M. V. (2000). Goal theory, motivation, and school achievement: An integrative review. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 51, 171–200 for a comprehensive review.
52. Heyman, G. D., Fu, G.-Y., & Lee, K. (2008). Reasoning about the disclosure of success and failure to friends among children in the United States and China. *Developmental Psychology*, 44(4), 908–918.
53. Oakes, J., & Guiton, G. (1995). Matchmaking: The dynamics of high school tracking decisions. *American Educational Research Journal*, 32(1), 3–33, pp. 10–11.
54. See note 53 to this chapter, p. 12.
55. Doidge, N. (2007). *The brain that changes itself: Stories of personal triumph from the frontiers of brain science*. New York: Penguin.
56. *Webster's new collegiate dictionary*. (1973). Springfield, MA: Merriam, p. 845.
57. Wang, Y.-T. (Ed.). (1992). *新現代漢語詞典* [A new dictionary of modern Chinese language]. Hainan: Hainan Publishing House, p. 1636.

58. It is important to point out that when scholars use the English term *peer* to describe Chinese, Japanese, and Korean *tongxue*, *douryou*, and *kyo-woo*, important cultural meanings are lost.
59. See note 5 to Chapter 2, p. 71.
60. See note 5 to Chapter 2, p. 75.
61. Legge, J. (Trans.). (1960). *The Chinese Classics, 5 volumes*. Hong Kong: University of Hong Kong. Songs 55, vol. IV.
62. See Child Welfare League Foundation (n.d.). *Report on school bullying*. Retrieved March 15, 2010 from http://www.children.org.tw/database_report.php?typeid=34 for increased bullying in Taiwanese schools as an example.
63. Chen, X.-Y. (2008, October) at the conference, *Bridging developmental and cultural psychology: New syntheses in theory, research, and policy*, Worcester, MA, Clark University. Although I am aware of no research on “nerds” in East Asian schools, all my personal inquiries with scholars across East Asian confirms that nerd harassment is virtually nonexistent in Hong Kong, China, Singapore, Japan, and Korea.
64. See the first reference in note 61 to Chapter 3.
65. See the second reference in note 46 to Chapter 4.
66. See the second reference in note 6 to Chapter 3.
67. Chen, X.-Y, Lei, C., Liu, H.-Y., & He, Y.-F. (2008). Effects of the peer group on the development of social functioning and academic achievement: A longitudinal study in Chinese children. *Child Development*, 79(2), 235–251.
68. See note 4 to this chapter.
69. Private communication with Yongmei Wang (March 14, 2010), a former lead teacher at Beijing 4th Secondary School for ten years. According to her, students at her school who did not achieve 85 out of 100 for all subjects including music, athletics, and art are automatically disqualified as nominees (as well as those who have too many absences). Anyone who qualifies can put him-/herself forward as a candidate for peers to vote for.
70. Private communication with Xiaoling Wang (March 14, 2010), a middle-school teacher in Beijing.
71. See note 52 to this chapter.
72. See the first reference in note 36 to Chapter 4 for an example. However, homework overload has been a controversial issue in East Asian education. A decade ago, China’s Education Ministry even passed regulations to set limits on how many hours of homework are permitted per day and to forbid schools and teachers to push children to take afterschool and weekend academic classes. However, this kind of policy did not meet with great success because parents still hire tutors and enroll their children in “cram” schools in order to help their children achieve even better.
73. Honor students at different levels receive different extra scores for entering more competitive middle schools, high schools, and colleges.
74. Periodical quizzes, midterms, and final exams are the means to determine student mastery. Homework in Russia is used for the same purposes. See Hufton, N., & Elloitt, J. (2000). Motivation to learn: The pedagogical nexus in the Russian school: Some implications for transnational research and policy borrowing. *Educational Studies*, 26, 115–122.
75. See the third reference in note 9 to Chapter 3.

76. Wilson, R. (1980). Conformity and deviance regarding moral rules in Chinese society: A socialization perspective. In A. Kleinman & T. Lin (Eds.), *Moral and abnormal behavior in Chinese culture* (pp. 117–136). Dordrecht: D. Reidel.
77. See note 38 to Chapter 4.
78. See the second reference in note 4 to Chapter 3, p. 19.
79. See the first reference in note 61 to Chapter 3.
80. See notes 52 and 67 to this chapter.
81. See note 3 to Chapter 1.
82. See note 16 to Chapter 5.
83. As discussed in Chapter 3, my lexicon study on learning terms showed that ability is placed as a consequence of learning on the Chinese conceptual map, but intelligence and ability for European Americans are placed as an internal learner characteristic that enables learning.
84. See the first reference in note 26 to Chapter 3.
85. See research findings on the susceptibility of Western adolescents to peer influence despite their stronger belief in the fixed self: Gardner, M., & Steinberg, L. (2005). Peer influence on risk taking, risk preference, and risky decision making in adolescence and adulthood: an experimental study. *Developmental Psychology*, 41(4), 625–635.
86. See the first reference in note 29 to Chapter 2.
87. Corriveau, K. H., & Harris, P. L. (2010). Preschoolers (sometimes) defer to the majority in making simple perceptual judgments. *Developmental Psychology*, 46(2), 437–445. Also see Hess, R. D., Azuma, H., Kashiwagi, K., Holloway, S. D., & Wenegrat, A. (1987). Cultural variations in socialization for school achievement: Contrasts between Japan and the United States. *Journal of Applied Developmental Psychology*, 8, 421–440; and Hess, R. D., Kashiwagi, K., Azuma, H., Price, G. G., & Dickson, W. P. (1980). Maternal expectations for mastery of developmental tasks in Japan and the United States. *International Journal of Psychology*, 15, 259–271 for Japanese mothers' greater expectation of their children's mastery of social courtesy, self-control, and compliance with authority, and how such maternal socialization predicts school achievement but is associated with negative outcomes among European-American children.
88. See note 8 to this chapter.
89. Presumably because Hungary is now a democracy and market economy. Fülöp's findings might have tapped increasing competition and decreasing cooperation in Hungary.
90. Watkins, D. A. (2009). Motivation and competition in Hong Kong secondary schools: The students' perspective. In C. Chan & N. Rao (Eds.), *Revisiting the Chinese learner: Psychological and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 71–88). Hong Kong: Comparative Education Research Centre (CERC), University of Hong Kong and Springer Press, pp. 82–84.
91. Kwan, V. S. Y., Bond, M. H., Boucher, H. C., Maslach, C., & Gan, Y. Q. (2002). The construct of individuation: More complex in collectivist than in individualist cultures. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 28, 300–310.
92. Please note that for older or younger female adults (than their mothers), children just call them ayi, which is still a deferential address, despite the fact that ayi is undifferentiated by age as their male counterparts.

93. See Liang, C.-H. (2007). Shame and pride: Age, kinship terms and socialization practice in a middle-class Taiwanese preschool. Poster presented at the Biannual Meetings of Society for Research in Child Development, Boston, MA; and Fung, H., & Liang, C. H. (2008). 越南媽媽,台灣囡仔: 台灣跨國婚姻家庭幼兒社會化之初探 [Vietnamese mothers, Taiwanese children: Socializing practices with young children in Sino-Vietnamese cross-border marriage families in Taipei, Taiwan]. *台灣人類學刊* [*Taiwan Journal of Anthropology*], 6, 47–88 for research on this topic. It is important to point out that cultural misunderstanding is common when Asian immigrant children attend host countries' schools. One of the Chinese first-graders in our current study lived in a suburban town with predominantly middle-class European-American residents. One day, this boy told his European-American peers that he had a sister. Surprised, the teacher called his mother and learned that this so-called sister was the boy's cousin and lived in China. Not knowing the significance of the Chinese family system and social relationships, this teacher proceeded to "correct" the boy by asking him to stand up and tell his class that he had no sister. Needless to say, this boy burst into tears because he was treated as an idiot and a liar. This is a sad but telling example of cultural insensitivity and misunderstanding (and poor teaching).
94. There is evidence that peer bullying is also on the rise in East Asia (see note 62 to this chapter). Some researchers report the Internet being a conduit that permits peer harassment without consequences. In Japan, social isolation and rejection have been reported; see, for example, Mishima, K. (1996). Bullying amongst close friends in elementary school. *Japanese Journal of Social Psychology*, 19(1), 41–50; and Masataka, N. (1999). Nihonteki ijime no seiritsu to ikuji [The formation of Japanese bullying and child-rearing]. *Japanese Journal of Addiction and Family*, 16(4), 438–444. As mentioned before, peer unkindness also exists in East Asia, and those who are perceived as lacking effort or being antisocial may face peer sanction. Research does need to pay attention to such peer problems. However, it is rare that high-achieving students suffer from peer harassment.
95. Johnson, D. (2009, Dec 7). Attacked Asian students afraid to go to school: 26 Asian students were attacked last week. Retrieved from November 20, 2010 from <http://www.nbcphiladelphia.com/news/local-beat/Attacked-Asian-Students-Fear-Returning-to-Class-78652997.html>
96. Rosenbloom, S. R., & Way, N. (2004). Experiences of discrimination among African American, Asian American, and Latino adolescents in an urban high school. *Youth & Society*, 35(4), 420–451, pp. 433–343.
97. Way, N. (2005). Seeking engagement: Reflections from a qualitative researcher. *Journal of Adolescent Research*, 20, 531–537.
98. Qin, D. B., Way, N., & Mukherjee, P. (2008). The other side of the model minority story the familial and peer challenges faced by Chinese American adolescents. *Youth & Society*, 39(4), 480–506.
99. See the last reference in note 35 to this chapter, pp. 18–19.